



Northern Berkshire Astronomical Society

Founded 2023 | North Adams Public Library | North Adams, MA

Northern Berkshire's home for amateur astronomy — whatever your experience, you belong under our skies!

Welcome to the Northern Berkshire Astronomical Society Star Party!

If you'd like to attend one of our public events, we'd love to share our passion for astronomy with you!

Event Rules & Etiquette

Our events are usually held at night - and in the dark - to ensure everyone has the best viewing experience and to protect sensitive equipment, please adhere to the following rules:

1. Lighting & Night Vision

Red Lights Only: Use only dim red-filtered flashlights. White light (including cell phones, tablets, and bright smartwatches) instantly ruins night vision, which takes 20-30 minutes to recover.

Vehicle Lighting: Disable interior dome lights and daytime running lights before arriving. If you must leave early, please park in the "Early Departure" zone and have a spotter help you exit without using headlights.

No Flash Photography: Electronic flashes are strictly prohibited in the observing area.

No Laser Pointers: unless the Event Coordinator has *explicitly approved them!*

2. Equipment Etiquette

Look, Don't Touch: Never touch a telescope or its mount. Even a light touch can cause the image to shake or move the object out of view.

Hands Off Glass: Do not touch any glass surfaces, including eyepieces and mirrors. Skin oils can damage optical coatings.

Watch for Cables: Be mindful of power cables and tripod legs on the ground to avoid tripping or knocking over equipment.

3. Safety & Environment

Drive with Caution: Speed limits are capped at 5 MPH. Be alert for pedestrians and equipment near the paths.

No Smoking/Vaping or Aerosols: Smoke and bug sprays can settle on telescope optics and cause permanent damage. Please apply sprays downwind and away from the telescopes.

Supervise Minors: Children are encouraged to attend but must be under adult supervision at all times. Running is not permitted in the observing area.

4. General Conduct

No Pets: To ensure the safety of our attendees and the protection of delicate equipment, pets are strictly prohibited from the observing area. The dark environment and presence of tripods make animals a significant tripping hazard.

Exception: Formally trained service animals as defined by the ADA are permitted but must be kept on a short leash at all times.

Keep it Quiet: Sound carries significantly at night. Please keep conversations at a low volume and silence all mobile devices.

Alcohol & Controlled Substances: To ensure the safety of our members and equipment, these are strictly prohibited at club events.

Pack It Out: We follow "Leave No Trace" principles. Please take all trash with you when you leave.

5. Solar Viewing Safety

If we have a daytime event that involves solar observing, these rules are *extremely important*:

WARNING: Looking at the Sun without proper protection can cause permanent blindness.

Certified Filters Only: Use only specialized solar filters or eclipse glasses that meet the **ISO 12312-2** international safety standard. Ordinary sunglasses, smoked glass, or homemade filters are **not safe**.

Equipment Inspection: Always inspect your solar filter or eclipse glasses before use. Discard them immediately if they are torn, scratched, punctured, or otherwise damaged.

Direct Viewing: Cover your eyes with your solar viewer *before* looking up at the Sun. Turn away from the Sun *before* removing the filter.

Telescope Safety: Solar filters must be securely attached to the ****front**** (objective end) of any telescope, binoculars, or camera lens. Never look through an optical device while wearing eclipse glasses—the concentrated rays will melt the filter and damage your eyes.

Continuous Supervision: Children must be supervised at all times when using solar viewers or telescopes.

6. Parking & Vehicle Etiquette

Designated Areas Only: Always park in the club's designated parking zones. If no specific area is marked, park well away from the telescope field to minimize dust and light interference for observers.

Park Facing the Exit: Whenever possible, park facing **AWAY** from the viewing area and toward the exit. This ensures that if you leave early, your headlights point away from the telescopes as you depart.

Early Departures: If you know you need to leave before the event officially ends, please park in the designated "Early Departure" area or the row furthest from the equipment.

Light Control: Before moving your vehicle, please announce your intention to leave so others can shield their equipment or eyes.

7. Weather & Cancellation Policy

Monitor the Forecast: Astronomy is entirely dependent on clear skies. Attendees are encouraged to monitor local weather forecasts leading up to the event.

Last-Minute Cancellations: Events may be cancelled at any time—including up to the last minute—due to inclement weather, high winds, or excessive cloud cover.

Status Updates: Please check our website <https://www.nbasastro.com> before heading out to confirm the event is still on. If "Go/No-Go" decisions are made, we will post the status there.

8. Staff Instructions

Obey NBAS Staff: For the safety of all participants and the protection of expensive equipment, please follow all instructions provided by NBAS staff and volunteers. They have the final say on site safety and etiquette.

Right of Refusal: NBAS staff reserve the right to ask any participant to relocate their equipment or leave the event if they are not adhering to these rules or are creating a hazard to others.

Disclaimer of Liability

Assumption of Risk: By attending this event, participants voluntarily assume all risks related to personal injury, illness, death, or property damage. This includes risks inherent to nighttime activities such as falls, contact with equipment, or travel to and from the site.

Equipment Damage: The Northern Berkshire Astronomical Society and its members are not responsible for any damage to personal equipment brought to the event. Attendees are solely responsible for securing and monitoring their own property.

Release and Waiver: Participants hereby release, waive, and discharge The Northern Berkshire Astronomical Society, its officers, volunteers, and agents from any and all liability for claims, costs, or expenses arising from participation in club activities.

Health and Safety: Attendees acknowledge they are in proper physical condition to participate and understand that some viewing sites may involve steep terrain or high altitudes.

Failure to follow these rules may result in being asked to leave the event.

Thank you for helping us keep the skies dark!

Guidelines for Enjoying the Event

1. Try to arrive early - this will help you get oriented, meet the NBAS staff, and you can look at the telescopes before it gets too dark!
2. Wear sensible clothing! Temperatures can drop suddenly, even in the summer. Bring a jacket or sweater to keep you comfortable. Layers are good, a hat is good.
3. If you're going to be watching for meteors, bring a reclining chair, and blankets!
4. Stay hydrated! Bring snacks, but keep them away from the area with telescopes.
5. Do a little background research - check one of our monthly star maps to see what constellations and planets might be up. Is there an object you've wanted to see through a telescope? Let us know - we might be able to point to it.
6. Ask questions! Our mission is to get more people engaged and active in astronomy, and we'd be more than happy to answer your questions.